

point of view, it is highly troublesome to download a set of apps and then find the correct app at the right time. Since messaging apps allow unlimited contact messages between recipients, consumers tend to stick with them.

Some of the most popular messaging apps include WhatsApp, Hike, Telegram, WeChat, Kik, Line, Snapchat and Viber. WhatsApp was acquired by Facebook even though it has its own messenger app integrated with its social website and as a standalone feature. Messaging apps are the future of marketing and if you are a brand, then you cannot afford to ignore this new and exciting field of social marketing.

Kik messenger has been used for marketing campaigns for longer than other messaging apps. The messaging app doesn't require a phone number for installation and use, it instead relies on usernames. Brands like MTV have been using Kik for marketing. Twentieth Century Fox used services of Kik by building a chatbot to generate publicity for its new film. The bot answered queries to potential viewers and helped in building interest.

Messaging app Line has been used by Coco Cola and McDonald's to market their products. It offers stickers and brands have the option of creating their personal accounts. Viber also offers similar services and has been used by Barclays Centre for marketing.

WeChat is a pioneer in the field of messaging apps and has successfully integrated mobile messaging with e-commerce. It offers purchase, option for playing games and also for taking orders right through its messaging app.

Future of Messaging apps

In 2013, WhatsApp came out with its broadcasting feature through which it is possible to send messages to a group of people without disclosing their identities. This is of benefit to social messaging marketers as it provides them with an instant outreach method of reaching out to their customers as opposed to traditional social marketing platforms such as Facebook where message delivery and read times are delayed. The BBC has used WhatsApp in the past for certain news items such as the Ebola crisis. It is not uncommon today for news articles published on BBC to give out WhatsApp numbers of their journalists and frequently asking readers if they'd like to talk or share information with a journalist regarding a news story.

In India, WhatsApp was used for sharing information, news and mobilizing people during the Chennai flood crisis. Absolut Vodka was another brand that made use of WhatsApp for a brilliant viral marketing campaign. Sven, a doorman released his WhatsApp number for Absolut Unique, a new